

by concerns of the military on both sides, until the dissolution of the USSR in December. The UN then took the lead, forming the Conference on Disarmament in 1994 to draw up a Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT) that banned all nuclear weapon and peaceful nuclear test explosions.

The US was the first country to sign the CTBT in 1996, and most states have since joined. Yet the treaty cannot come into effect until it is not only signed, but ratified, by all 44 members of the Conference, including all the nuclear powers. By 2019, 168 countries had ratified the CTBT, and another 17 countries had signed but not ratified it. Crucially, five of the original 44 Conference members (China, Egypt, Iran, Israel, and the US) have not yet ratified the treaty, and three more (India, North Korea, and Pakistan) have not even signed it.

Stand-off

Although the CTBT has not come into effect, there has been progress. The US and Russia greatly reduced their nuclear warhead numbers, under the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty (INF Treaty)

of 1987. The NPT was renewed indefinitely in 1995 and had 191 signatories by 2020.

Since the PTBT, only Pakistan, India, North Korea, and probably Israel are known to have acquired nuclear weapons. However, Iran has been accused of illegally enriching uranium to make bombs. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) demanded access for verification, and international sanctions were imposed from 2006. Intense diplomatic negotiations continue in an attempt to deter Iran from creating a nuclear arsenal.

North Korea, too, has plowed on with its nuclear program despite international sanctions. Between 2006 and 2017, it held six major underground nuclear tests (detected by US Geological Survey seismographs), and in 2017, it claimed to have perfected a hydrogen bomb. Meanwhile, the five main nuclear powers, especially the US and China, still seem no nearer to eliminating their nuclear arsenals. In 2019, the US backed out of the INF Treaty.

There is now a complex body of international law reflecting 70 years of intense negotiation to keep the

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All nations should declare ... that nuclear weapons must be destroyed. This is to save ourselves and our planet.

Mikhail Gorbachev
Soviet general secretary (1985–1991),
BBC interview, 2019

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threat of war at bay. The IAEA upholds these treaties, monitoring nuclear activity in more than 140 countries, but many states do not give the inspectorate free access. The International Court of Justice adjudicates treaty infringements, but some states have refused to abide by its judgments. As long as nuclear and other weapons of mass destruction exist, the danger remains, and efforts to uphold and extend disarmament treaties continue. ■

